

# Tower of London - Kids

## UK Family Tour

### The White Tower: 950 Years Old

The huge square castle in the middle is the White Tower, and it's the reason this whole place is called the Tower of London. William the Conqueror started building it around 1078, just twelve years after he invaded England and won the Battle of Hastings. Think about that: this building is nearly a thousand years old. William built it to scare Londoners — a giant stone fortress towering over their wooden houses, saying “I’m in charge now.” The walls are up to four and a half meters thick. That’s thicker than your bedroom is long. The stone was shipped all the way from Caen in France, because William didn’t trust English stone — or maybe English builders. Over the centuries the Tower has been a fortress, a palace, a prison, a mint where coins were made, and even a zoo. Inside the White Tower today you’ll find the Royal Armouries, including King Henry the Eighth’s actual armor. Look closely at how it gets bigger over his lifetime — you can literally watch the king getting rounder, suit by suit. His last armor would fit a man with a 52-inch waist.

Related listening: 1066 joins them: the Viking Age ended near York the same year the Conqueror’s Tower story began. Coming up — “The Battle That Ended the Vikings” (JORVIK & Viking York, Day 14).

### Why the White Tower Is White

Here’s a riddle. Why is the White Tower called white, when the stone you’re looking at is a soft, sandy grey? The answer is paint. Back in the year 1240, a king named Henry the Third gave a strange order. He told his workmen to whitewash the whole enormous keep, inside and out, until it gleamed like a giant sugar cube. Imagine it. A snow-white castle, thirty meters tall, blazing in the sunlight above a brown and muddy city. You could probably have seen it shining from miles down the river. The paint has long since worn away, but the name stuck, and that is why we still call it the White Tower today.

Now look up at the roof. See the four little towers, one at each corner? Three of them are square, but one, the one on the north-east, is round. That round turret hides a spiral staircase twisting up inside it, and hundreds of years ago a clever astronomer used it to watch the stars, before there was any better place in London to do it. On top, watch for the golden weathervanes spinning in the wind.

Here is something your eyes can check for themselves. The walls are not straight up and down like a modern building. They lean in very slightly as they rise, getting thinner toward the top, which makes the whole tower feel even more solid and heavy, as if it has been planted into the ground and will never, ever move. And the bottom corners flare out into a thick stone skirt, so that anything dropped from the battlements above, a rock, or a bucket of something horrible, would bounce off the slope and fly out sideways into the attackers. Nothing here is an accident.

And the stone keeps changing. The original creamy French stone crumbles in England’s rain, so over the centuries builders have patched and re-faced the walls again and again with tougher English stone. So when you touch this wall, you are touching almost a thousand years of repairs, one on top of another. Put

your hand flat against it. Somewhere under your palm is the oldest wall in London.

## **The Line of Kings and Henry's Armour**

Step inside and you'll meet the oldest tourist attraction in the whole world. It is called the Line of Kings, and people have been coming to gawp at it for more than three hundred years, which means the children of King Charles the Second once stood roughly where you are standing now, mouths open, looking at the very same thing.

Here is what they saw, and what you'll see. A parade of life-sized wooden horses, carved and painted, each one carrying the armour of a famous English king, as if the kings themselves had ridden out of history and lined up for inspection. Some of those wooden horses are around three hundred and twenty-five years old, older than almost any toy or statue you will ever meet. The whole display was a kind of show-off, a way of telling visitors, look how long and grand and unbroken our line of kings has been. It was propaganda with hooves.

Now find the armour of Henry the Eighth, and get ready to giggle, because Henry never did anything quietly. This is a real suit of steel, made to fit his actual body around the year 1540, when he had grown huge and powerful and knew it. And right in the middle, ahem, is the codpiece, a bulging steel pouch that armoured, well, exactly the part you're thinking of. It is enormous, and it was meant to be. It shouted to the whole court that here stood a big, strong, kingly king.

And here is the truly strange part. For hundreds of years, women visitors believed that if they poked a pin into Henry's steel codpiece, it would magically help them have a baby. People genuinely did this, over and over, for centuries. So somewhere on that shining armour are the tiny scratches of thousands of hopeful visitors and their pins. History is often much weirder than any tale someone could make up. Look closely, keep a straight face if you can, and remember, the real Henry once breathed and sweated inside that very metal.

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## The Crown Jewels: The World's Most Guarded Sparkle

You're about to see the most valuable collection of objects in Britain — and stand on a moving walkway so nobody hogs the view. The Crown Jewels include crowns, scepters, orbs, and swords that are still used today when a king or queen is crowned. Look for the Imperial State Crown: it has two thousand eight hundred and sixty-eight diamonds, plus rubies, sapphires, emeralds, and pearls. Then find the Sovereign's Sceptre. The giant diamond at the top is called the Cullinan One, or the Great Star of Africa — cut from the largest gem diamond ever found. The original rough stone, found in South Africa in 1905, was the size of a grapefruit. When it was sent to England, guards made a big show of putting a fake on a ship — the real diamond traveled in a plain box, by ordinary post. In 1671, a man called Colonel Blood actually tried to steal the Crown Jewels. He flattened a crown with a mallet and stuffed it under his coat, and got caught at the gate. Amazingly, the king pardoned him — and even gave him land. Nobody knows why.

Related listening: England's Crown Jewels and Scotland's older Honours, each with its own famous heist story. Coming up — “The Hidden Crown and the Stolen Stone” (Edinburgh Castle, Day 9).

### Colonel Blood's Impossible Heist

You already heard that a man once tried to steal the Crown Jewels. Now here is how he almost pulled it off, because it is one of the cheekiest robberies in all of history.

His name was Thomas Blood, and he called himself Colonel, though nobody was quite sure he really was one. In the spring of 1671 he showed up at the Tower dressed as a friendly old parson, with a woman pretending to be his wife. In those days, if you tipped the keeper, he would show you the Crown Jewels in private, and the keeper was a trusting old man named Talbot Edwards. Blood visited again and again, being charming, making friends, until one day he even suggested that his handsome young nephew should marry the keeper's daughter. It was all a trick. He was playing the long game.

On the morning of the ninth of May, Blood arrived with that so-called nephew and two other men, and asked dear old Mister Edwards for one last private peek at the jewels. The moment the door was unlocked, they pounced. They threw a cloak over the old man, knocked him down with a wooden mallet, and got to work. Blood squashed the crown flat with the mallet so it would fit under his coat. One accomplice stuffed the golden orb, that heavy ball, straight down his baggy trousers. And the third man started sawing the royal sceptre in half, because it was too long to hide.

But old Mister Edwards was tougher than he looked. He came round and started roaring, murder, treason, at the top of his lungs. The thieves panicked, dropped the sceptre, and ran, waddling, remember, one of them had a golden orb down his pants, and they were caught right at the gate.

Now the strangest bit. You would expect Blood to lose his head. Instead the king, Charles the Second, asked to meet this outrageous robber, was so tickled by his nerve that he pardoned him completely, gave him back his lands in Ireland, and handed him a yearly income. To this day nobody really knows why. Some people think the king secretly admired a good scoundrel. Others whisper that the king was somehow in on it.

### The Spoon That Survived

In a room full of gold and giant diamonds, I want you to hunt for something small, plain, and easy to miss. It is a golden spoon. And it is, quietly, the most amazing object in here.

Here is why. Almost everything in the Jewel House is less than four hundred years old, and there is a grim reason for that. Long ago, England had a civil war. The king lost, and the winners decided to destroy the old Crown Jewels completely. They pried out the jewels to sell, and they melted the ancient golden crowns down into coins. Centuries of treasure, gone in the fire. But two little things escaped. One was a golden eagle bottle that holds the holy oil. And the other was this spoon.

The Coronation Spoon is more than eight hundred years old. It was already old and famous back when knights in armour clanked around England. When the great meltdown came, a quick-thinking man simply bought the spoon and hid it, then handed it back once a king ruled again. And it still has a job to do. At the crowning of a new king or queen, holy oil is poured into that spoon and used to anoint the ruler, dabbed onto the head and the hands, the single most sacred moment of the whole ceremony. When King Charles was crowned in 2023, this exact spoon, this eight-hundred-year-old survivor, was there doing its ancient work.

Now, one number to blow your mind before you leave. Somebody has actually counted every single gemstone in the whole Crown Jewels collection. Ready? Twenty-three thousand, five hundred and seventy-eight. Diamonds, rubies, sapphires, emeralds, and pearls, all sparkling across around a hundred and forty golden objects. And here is the thing people forget. These are not museum leftovers stuck behind glass forever. They are real, working tools of a real monarchy, taken out, worn, and used at coronations and grand ceremonies, then brought back here to sleep. So look one more time at that little spoon. It has seen every English coronation for eight hundred years. It has watched them all.

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## The Ravens: The Tower's Feathered Guards

See those big black birds strutting around like they own the place? They kind of do. These are the Tower ravens, and legend says that if the ravens ever leave the Tower, the kingdom of England will fall. Nobody wants to test it, so at least six ravens are kept here at all times — plus a spare, just in case. They have names, a special keeper called the Ravenmaster, and a fancy diet of raw meat and biscuits soaked in blood. Occasionally they get a whole boiled egg as a treat. Their wing feathers are trimmed just enough so they don't fly far, but ravens are escape artists anyway. One raven, called Grog, ran away in 1981 and was last seen outside a pub. Another was fired — actually officially dismissed — for eating television aerials and attacking cars. Ravens are among the smartest birds on Earth. They can mimic human voices, solve puzzles, and hold grudges — they remember faces of people who annoy them for years. So be polite. Don't try to pet them: their beaks are strong enough to crack bones, and the Ravenmaster says they bite him all the time.

### The Raven Cemetery and Their Clever Games

Somewhere in the dry moat, on the south side near the river gate, there is a small patch of ground you might walk right past. It is the raven cemetery. When a Tower raven dies, it is not simply forgotten. It gets buried here, and its name is added to a memorial stone that lists the Tower's feathered guardians going all the way back to the nineteen-fifties. Names like Ronald and Rhys and Gwylum rest under that grass. These birds get farewells fit for soldiers, because in a way, that is exactly what they are.

The ravens strutting about today have names too, and the list keeps changing as old birds retire and new ones are sworn in. A recent flock included Poppy, Edgar, Georgie, and one splendidly named Poe, after the poet who wrote a famous spooky poem about a raven. Say hello, but keep your snacks firmly in your pocket.

So why does everyone say ravens are so clever? Watch closely and you might catch them at it. A raven will hide food, tucking a scrap of meat under a leaf or into a crack, and it can remember hundreds of these secret hiding spots for weeks afterward. Sneakier still, if a raven thinks another bird is spying on it, it will make a big show of hiding the food in the wrong place, then slip the real treasure somewhere else the moment the spy looks away. That is not instinct. That is a bird telling a lie.

They play, too, purely for fun. Ravens have been filmed sliding down snowy roofs on their backs, over and over, like children on a sledge, then flapping back up to do it again. They can copy sounds they hear, and a Tower raven has been known to croak out a gravelly good morning at startled visitors. And they sometimes bring little gifts, a shiny button, a bottle cap, to people they have decided they like.

So do not think of them as decorations. Think of them as clever, funny, slightly cheeky characters who happen to hold the whole kingdom's luck in their beaks. Watch what they do today. They are absolutely watching you.

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## Prisoners, Traitors and a Polar Bear

The Tower's scariest job was being a prison. Prisoners often arrived by boat through Traitors' Gate — look for the big arch by the river. Imagine gliding through it, knowing you might never come out. Two of King Henry the Eighth's own wives, Anne Boleyn and Catherine Howard, were imprisoned and executed here. So were two young princes, aged twelve and nine, who were locked in the Tower in 1483 and simply vanished. Two hundred years later, workmen found a box of children's bones under a staircase. It's still one of history's great unsolved mysteries. But the Tower wasn't all doom. For six hundred years it was also a royal zoo! Kings received exotic animals as presents: lions, an elephant from the King of France, ostriches, and — best of all — a polar bear from Norway in 1252. The bear was kept on a long chain so it could swim in the River Thames and catch its own fish. Imagine walking along the river and seeing a polar bear splash past. Look for the wire animal sculptures around the grounds — they mark where the zoo animals once lived.

Related listening: Two of Henry's queens link these places: accused at Hampton Court, executed at the Tower. Coming up — "The Screaming Gallery: Britain's Most Haunted Palace" (Hampton Court Palace, Day 7).

## The Last People Executed Here

When you think of executions at the Tower, you probably picture an axe and a wooden block, hundreds of years ago. But here is something that surprises almost everyone. The very last person put to death at the Tower of London was not a medieval queen or a Tudor traitor. It was a spy, and it happened in 1941, during the Second World War, close enough that a few people alive today can still remember that war.

His name was Josef Jakobs, a German spy who parachuted into England in the dark to send secrets back to the enemy. But his mission went wrong from the very first second, because as he landed he broke his ankle, and he lay there helpless in a field until a farmer found him the next morning. He was caught almost at once. Because his broken leg meant he could not stand up straight to face the firing squad, the soldiers did something eerie. They sat him down in an ordinary brown wooden chair, pinned a small white target over his heart, and eight soldiers fired at dawn. He was the very last. Nobody has been executed at the Tower since.

And he was not the only spy shot here. During the First World War, eleven enemy spies were caught and shot by firing squad at a little rifle range inside these very walls. So this ancient castle was still a place of life and death well into modern times.

Now, if you want the strangest execution story of all, go back to the year 1747 and a rebel lord named Simon Fraser. His beheading on Tower Hill drew such an enormous crowd that people built rickety wooden viewing stands, packed shoulder to shoulder, to get a better look. And just before the axe fell, one of those crowded stands groaned, cracked, and collapsed, and around nine people who had come to watch a death were killed themselves. And old Lord Fraser, when they told him? He actually laughed and said the more mischief, the better the sport. He was the last man in all of Britain ever to have his head chopped off. After him, that gruesome custom stopped forever.

## The Ghosts of the Tower

With so many unhappy endings in one place, it is no wonder the Tower is said to be the most haunted spot in all of England. Now, nobody can prove a single ghost, and plenty of people have spent whole

nights here and seen nothing but shadows. But the stories are wonderful, and the Yeoman Warders love to tell them, so here are the best. Just remember, these are tales, not facts.

The most famous ghost of all is said to be Anne Boleyn, the queen who lost her head on Tower Green. For hundreds of years, guards have sworn they saw a woman in an old-fashioned gown drifting across the green toward the little chapel where she is buried, sometimes, they say, carrying her own head tucked under her arm. One night long ago, a soldier on guard claimed he saw her coming and shouted for her to stop, and when she kept gliding straight toward him, he fainted clean away.

Then there are the two little princes, the boys who vanished from the Tower long ago. The story goes that people have glimpsed two small figures in white nightgowns, holding hands, standing silently in a dark doorway of the Bloody Tower, before melting into the wall. Sad little ghosts, if they are there at all.

The strangest tale comes from the Martin Tower, where the Crown Jewels were once kept. In 1817 the Keeper of the Jewels was having supper with his family when, he later wrote, a glowing tube of swirling blue liquid floated through the room, hovered over his wife, then vanished. He insisted for the rest of his life that it was real, and nobody has ever explained it.

There are more. A giant bear that guards supposedly fled from, cold spots on the stairs, footsteps in empty rooms. Do I believe them? I will let you decide. But here is my honest advice for today. As the afternoon light fades and the crowds thin out, stand quietly for a moment near Tower Green, feel how old and heavy the silence is, and ask yourself, just quietly, whether you would really want to be locked in here after dark.

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## The Beefeaters: Living Inside a Castle

The guards in the dark blue and red uniforms are Yeoman Warders — everyone calls them Beefeaters. Nobody's completely sure why. The best guess is that centuries ago they were paid partly in beef from the king's table, which honestly sounds like a good deal. Here's the amazing part: to become a Beefeater you must serve at least twenty-two years in the armed forces with a spotless record. And they don't just work at the Tower — they live here, inside the walls, with their families. About a hundred and fifty people call this castle home. There's even a doctor and a chaplain. Kids have grown up here, and the Tower has its own private pub for residents called The Keys. Every single night for over seven hundred years, the Beefeaters have locked the Tower gates in a ritual called the Ceremony of the Keys, at exactly 9:53 PM. It has never been cancelled — not even during the Blitz in World War Two, when bombs were falling. One night a bomb blast knocked the escort off their feet mid-ceremony. They got up, dusted off, and finished locking up — then wrote a letter of apology to the King for being late. He wrote back: don't worry about it.

### Two Uniforms and a Barrel of Rum

Take a good look at a Beefeater's outfit, because there is not one uniform, there are two, and they are wildly different. The one you will see today is called the blue undress, dark navy blue with red trimmings and a jaunty little hat, and believe it or not, it is the everyday work clothes. Queen Victoria's people invented it back in the eighteen-fifties, because the fancy version was so heavy and so expensive that wearing it every day was a nightmare.

That fancy version is the one you have seen in pictures, the magnificent scarlet-and-gold coat that looks straight out of a Tudor painting. It is called the state dress, and its design goes back around five hundred years, to the time of the Tudor kings. It weighs a ton, it takes ages to put on, and the Beefeaters only wear it for the very grandest occasions. So if you spot one in red and gold, you will know it is a special day.

Now here is a mix-up that drives Beefeaters slightly bonkers. There is another group of guards, called the Yeomen of the Guard, who wear an almost identical red-and-gold outfit. But they are not the same people at all. The Yeomen of the Guard are the king's personal bodyguards, and you can tell them apart by a strap that crosses their chest from one shoulder down to the waist. The Beefeaters do not wear that strap. Same fabulous costume, completely different job, so try never to mix them up in front of a Beefeater.

And here is my very favourite Tower tradition of all. Whenever a Royal Navy warship sails up the River Thames and ties up at the Tower's wharf, the captain has to pay an ancient toll, and not in money. He pays in a barrel of rum. It is called the Constable's Dues, it is hundreds of years old, and yes, it genuinely still happens today. The Beefeaters march the barrel in with great ceremony and hand it over to the Tower's Constable. Just imagine, a castle that collects its rent in rum. Somewhere out there, a whole navy owes this place a drink.